AUTOMATON OF SHALE

Full rules • revised playtest sequence • 17 September 2026

Program a shale automaton through three cycles of increasingly fragile competence, then survive Advanced Programming. Nobulous is observing. This has not improved the working conditions.

Components

- 3 double-sided Technician cards (6 Technicians)
- 8 double-sided Program cards in each deck: Routine, Specialized, and Unstable
- 8 double-sided Advanced Program cards
- 6 Limitation cards
- 5 Element allocation mats
- The 17 unit dice: 4 Purple, 4 Blue, 4 Green, 4 Yellow, and 1 Red
- Health, Strategy, and Recovery stat dice, plus the Chip

Setup

1. Choose a Technician. All begin at **2 HP / 2 STR / 3 REC**.

2. Choose one Program deck: **Routine** is the teaching deck, **Specialized** is the intended experience, and **Unstable** is experimental and very hard.

3. Shuffle the 6 Limitations.

4. Shuffle the 8 Advanced Programs and set them aside.

5. Lay out the Element mats. All 17 dice begin available.

Objective and deck cycles

Cycle through the chosen Program deck three times, then face three Advanced Programs. Finish Advanced Programming with at least 1 HP to win. If HP reaches 0, you lose. HP may never exceed 6.

A cycle is one pass through every Program still in the deck. Shuffle at the start of each cycle. Programs that are set aside or removed by a reward do not return, so later cycles may be shorter. After the third cycle—or as soon as the deck is empty—begin Advanced Programming.

Running a Program

Use this sequence. The Limitation is known before dice are committed.

Step	Procedure
Reveal	Reveal the Program and one Limitation together.
Apply the Limitation	Withhold the indicated dice from the available pool.
Commit required colors	Place one available die matching every colored dot onto that element. Red cannot satisfy a required-color dot.
Finish allocation	Distribute any remaining available dice among the elements. An element may receive no dice and will then fail.
Execute	Roll and resolve each element separately. A Hit is 1 success; a Crit is 2.
Recover	After the Program, recover dice equal to REC before revealing the next Program.

Required colors

Required dice are locked to their printed elements and count normally toward those Targets. If a Limitation leaves you unable to supply every required color, lose 1 HP, do not execute the Program, and treat it as failed for Stable/Overheated progression.

Deck	Required-color dots per Program
Routine	1
Specialized	2
Unstable	1
Advanced	2

Limitations

- Yellow, Green, Blue, or Purple Shortage: withhold 2 dice of that color.
- Diversity Protocol: withhold 2 dice of different non-Red colors.
- Red Quarantine: withhold the Red die.
- Withheld dice return when the Program ends. Discard the Limitation afterward.

Allocation threshold

Target +1 dice is the safe allocation threshold for an element, not a cap. You may allocate more, but every die beyond the safe threshold exhausts after that element resolves, regardless of outcome.

Strategy rolls and resolution

Each element receives one initial roll. Additional rolls up to STR form a shared pool for the entire Program. At STR 2, you have one additional roll total. Unless Compiler changes the procedure, an additional roll rerolls every die on that element and replaces the prior result, better or worse.

Result	Consequence
Exactly Target	Optimal Implementation: recover 2 exhausted dice.
Target +1	No penalty.
Target +2 or more	Exhaust 1 die allocated to that element.
Failure	Exhaust every die allocated to that element.
Used an additional STR roll	That element's dice exhaust regardless of outcome.

If an additional roll lands exactly on Target, both effects apply: exhaust the element's dice first, then recover 2; those recovered dice may include dice just exhausted.

Catastrophic Failure

One failed element costs no HP. Two or more failed elements in one Program cause one Catastrophic Failure and cost 1 HP total.

Program rewards

Complete a Routine, Specialized, or Unstable Program with **no failed elements** to claim its printed reward. Advanced Programs have no reward.

Printed reward	Effect
Gain 1 HP	Increase HP by 1, to a maximum of 6.
Recover 3 exhausted dice	Recover any 3 exhausted dice.
Banish 1 Limitation	Remove that Limitation from the game.
Return 1 Overheated Program to Stable	Flip one Overheated Program to its Stable face.
+1 REC; remove this Program	Increase REC permanently, then remove the rewarded Program.
+1 STR; remove this Program	Increase STR permanently, then remove the rewarded Program.

Stable, Overheated, and set aside

- When a Stable Program fails, it becomes Overheated.
- When that Overheated Program fails on a later appearance, set it aside.
- A successful Program keeps its current face unless a reward changes it.

Technicians

Technician	Ability
Architect — Reconfigure	Once per Program, before rolling an element, move up to 2 allocated dice between unresolved elements.
Debugger — Debug	Once per Program, after failing by exactly 1 success, reroll 1 allocated die. If it still fails, exhaust that die.
Optimizer — Optimize	Once per Program, Target +1 successes may count as Optimal Implementation.
Engineer — Redundancy	For up to 2 elements per Program, the safe allocation threshold is Target +2 instead of Target +1.
Operator — Workaround	When a non-Red Limitation would withhold 2 dice, you may withhold 1 of those dice as another non-Red color instea
Compiler — Compile	When spending an additional STR roll, reroll any number of dice on that element while keeping the others.

Advanced Programming

- Select 3 Advanced Programs. They contain 4 or 5 printed elements and 2 required-color dots.
- Recover normally between Advanced Programs.
- Set-aside Programs may be tucked beneath the left or right edge of an Advanced Program; the exposed edge Target adds an element. If the marked element is first or last, use that edge; if internal, choose either edge.
- Advanced Program 1 begins Stable.
- After 0–1 failed elements, the next Advanced Program begins Stable.
- After 2 or more failed elements, lose 1 HP from Catastrophic Failure and begin the next Advanced Program Overheated.
- Complete all three Advanced Programs with HP remaining to win.

Nobulous Research Journal carry-forward

When playing the NRJ campaign, retain the 3 Advanced Programs you faced, preserving whether each was Stable or Overheated. Add 3 unused Advanced Programs as candidates, for 6 AoS cards in the Research Pool.

Rules source: September 11, 2026 Nobulous Set compendium, updated here so Limitations are revealed and applied before required-color dice are committed. Card-specific text overrides this reference if a later card revision conflicts.